



Held 9–10 September 2026 in Abia State, Nigeria

INTRODUCTION

The Southeast Migration Dialogue (SEMD) 2026, convened by the Civil Society Network on Migration and Development (CSOnetMADE) and hosted by the Abia State Government, held from 9–10 September 2026 at the Banquet Hall, Government House, Umuahia, Abia State. The SEMD brought together relevant stakeholders from government, development and international partners, civil society, academia, the private sector, diaspora structures, traditional and community institutions, and other actors to deliberate on migration governance from a Southeast perspective.

The Dialogue provided a strategic platform to examine opportunities, responsibilities and emerging priorities for strengthening state level migration governance and advancing the implementation of the Revised 2025 National Migration Policy (NMP) across the Southeast. Discussions centred on the need to translate national migration priorities into coordinated state and community-level action, while recognising migration as both a governance responsibility and an opportunity for regional development.

Participants highlighted the importance of strengthening state-level coordination mechanisms, promoting regular migration and labour mobility, harnessing diaspora contributions, supporting returning migrants and reintegration, strengthening evidence-based policy through research and reliable migration data, and ensuring meaningful participation of communities and non-state actors.

The Dialogue further recognised that effective migration governance in the Southeast requires functional state-level structures, stronger inter-state and inter-agency coordination, sustained partnerships and a whole-of-government and whole-of-society approach that connects federal and state institutions with communities and other non-state actors.

KEY MESSAGES AND PRIORITY ACTIONS

Participants identified the following as key priorities for strengthening migration governance in the SouthEast:

1. **Strengthen State-Level Migration Governance Structures:** Southeast States should establish or strengthen appropriate state-level migration coordination structures in line with the Revised 2025 NMP, including dedicated Migration Desks where appropriate. Existing structures may provide useful lessons for other states.
2. **Strengthen Migration Research and Evidence:** Universities and research institutions should promote context-specific research on migration in the SouthEast, including the development and expansion of postgraduate migration studies programmes, to strengthen evidence-based policy and programming.
3. **Harness Diaspora Contributions:** Southeast States should develop mechanisms to harness diaspora skills, knowledge, networks, entrepreneurship and investment for regional development, while ensuring safe and supportive conditions for diaspora engagement and the return of diaspora members, leveraging inter-state experience sharing.
4. **Promote Regular Migration Pathways:** Stakeholders should strengthen public awareness of safe and regular migration pathways, particularly among young people, through academic institutions, learning centres, communities, media and other appropriate platforms.
5. **Strengthen Community and Grassroots Participation:** Migration governance should meaningfully engage traditional and community leaders, persons with disabilities, women, young people, returnees, migrants and other vulnerable groups to ensure that no one is left behind.
6. **Engage the Private Sector:** The private sector should be recognised and actively engaged as a key partner in migration governance, particularly in relation to employment, labour mobility, skills development, entrepreneurship and investment.
7. **Strengthen Migration Data:** States should strengthen the generation, sharing and utilisation of reliable, timely and disaggregated migration data to inform planning, policy development and programming.

KEY MESSAGES AND PRIORITY ACTIONS

8. **Strengthen Return, Readmission and Reintegration:** State and non-state actors should strengthen coordination and referral systems for returnees and ensure that reintegration interventions are linked to existing livelihood, social protection, health and community development programmes.
9. **Address Climate and Human Mobility:** Migration and human mobility considerations should be integrated into climate change adaptation, disaster risk reduction and development planning across the Southeast.

RESOLUTIONS AND CALLS TO ACTION

A. Southeast State Governments and State MDAs

Participants call on Southeast State Governments and relevant MDAs to:

- Establish or strengthen state-level migration coordination mechanisms in line with the Revised 2025 NMP and designate institutional focal points or Migration Desks to facilitate coordination and follow-up on migration-related priorities.
- Ensure continuity of the Southeast dialogue annually.
- Integrate migration priorities into state development plans, sectoral plans and relevant budgets for the implementation of the Southeast migration strategy.
- Strengthen coordination among state and non-state actors in the Southeast.
- Support the generation, management and use of migration data for evidence-based planning.
- Establish a Southeast Migration Working Group (SMWG) to coordinate the implementation of the recommendations. (The conveners of this maiden southeast dialogue can lead this action).

B. Federal Government and Migration Institutions

Participants call on relevant federal institutions, particularly NCFRMI and other migration-related agencies, to:

- Encourage the presence of NCFRMI in the Southeastern states.
- Provide technical guidance and support to Southeast States in establishing and operationalising state-level migration coordination mechanisms.
- Support states with relevant migration data, technical resources and capacity development.
- Facilitate stronger coordination among federal institutions operating at state level.

C. Academia and Research Institutions

- Promote the generation and utilisation of reliable migration data.
- Expand migration research by generating context-specific evidence on migration trends, labour mobility, diaspora, return and reintegration, climate mobility and migrant protection.
- Strengthen collaboration with government and other stakeholders to ensure that research findings inform policy and programming.

D. Civil Society and Community Actors

- Strengthen grassroots awareness of safe and regular migration pathways.
- Support migrant protection, return and reintegration and community-based responses.
- Ensure that government policies and programmes on migration reach the grassroots through real time independent monitoring.
- Strengthen advocacy for inclusive and accountable migration governance.
- Facilitate meaningful participation of migrants, returnees, persons with disabilities, women, young people and other vulnerable groups.

E. Private Sector and Diaspora

- Promote decent employment, skills development, entrepreneurship and investment opportunities.
- Develop sustainable mechanisms for diaspora knowledge, skills, networks and investment to contribute to Southeast development.
- Support initiatives that create viable alternatives and opportunities for young people.

F. Media

- Ensure real-time migration reportage that captures diverse perspectives, including those of migrants, returnees, communities and relevant stakeholders.
- Integrate traditional and community-based communication channels to strengthen grassroots reach and ensure migration information reaches underserved communities.

G. Development and International Partners

Participants call on development and international partners to:

- Strengthen their presence in the Southeast, providing technical and strategic support for the implementation of the Revised 2025 NMP at zonal level.
- Support capacity strengthening, research, data generation and coordination mechanisms.
- Promote partnerships that strengthen local and state ownership and sustainability.
- Support innovative approaches to regular migration, migrant protection, return and reintegration, diaspora engagement and climate mobility.

CONCLUSION

The Southeast Migration Dialogue 2026 reaffirmed that effective migration governance requires strong institutions, reliable evidence, meaningful participation and sustained partnerships. Participants recognised the significant contribution that migration and diaspora engagement can make to the development of the Southeast when migration is safe, regular, orderly and well governed.

Participants therefore pledged their continued collaboration towards decentralised, evidence-based, inclusive and coordinated migration governance across the Southeast, in furtherance of the Revised 2025 National Migration Policy and the wellbeing and development of migrants, returnees, families and communities.

The Dialogue further committed stakeholders to translating the outcomes of this meeting into practical actions, stronger partnerships and sustained engagement at state, regional and national levels.

Done at Umuahia, Abia State, Nigeria, this 10th day of September 2026.

Motion for Adoption by:

Sir Chris Onwuegbu, JP

Perm. Sec. Abia State Min. of Information

Seconded by:

Mrs Chinemerem Goodness Mgbaja

CSOnetMADE Ebonyi State Coordinator

Signed:



Jeto Nwadi

Zonal Coordinator CSOnetMADE

Convener SEMD



Dr. Charles Ukauwa,

Abia State Coordinator CSOnetMADE,

Local Organising Committee Chairman



Venerable Dr. O.I.G Onyeagaocha

Permanent Secretary, Imo State Ministry of Humanitarian Affairs,

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